

Learning How to Work

Pam's story resonates with me. I think her father and my grandfather would have gotten along. I spent a lot of time with my grandparents as a kid, and my grandfather taught me the value and dignity in a good day's work. This guy was tireless. He was up at 3:00 a.m. every day to go work in a factory. He'd get home late in the afternoon, eat some dinner, change his clothes, and then move on to some project around the house. I'd find him under a car, up on the roof, painting a bedroom—wherever there was work to be done, my grandfather was there doing it. He never seemed to get tired, and he never sat still for too long. He was a man of few words, but no one ever taught me more about the value of work than he did. I can't quote any catchy one-liner or specific piece of advice he gave me about work, though. He *taught* me by *showing* me. It's a lesson that's shaped my life.

Maybe you had a parent or grandparent like that. You know, someone who was always shuffling around from one task to another, teaching you by their words and actions what it meant to work hard. I've heard things like, "If a job's worth doing, it's worth doing right." Or maybe, "It's always easier to do a job right the first time than to redo it a second time." Or, one of my favorites, "Don't do anything halfway. Either do the whole job or don't bother." These little bits of wisdom aren't simply "dad speak." They actually go back hundreds and thousands of years. Ben Franklin was thought to have said, "Motivation is when your dreams put on work clothes," and Thomas Edison is known for the adage, "Opportunity is missed by most people because it's dressed in overalls and looks like work." The Bible even has plenty to say about work, such as, "All hard work brings a profit, but mere talk leads only to poverty" (Proverbs 14:23). These timeless pieces of wisdom point to the inescapable fact that work—and our attitude about work—matters more than we might think.